G Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) Program

The Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) Program provides necessary non-ambulance transportation to Medicaid recipients for medical care or treatment covered by Medicaid.

The program ensures that transportation services are:

- Comparable in scope and duration statewide, with some variation based on local resources
- Consistent with the best interest of recipients
- Appropriate to the recipient's needs, location, and available services
- Timely, cost-effective, and efficient

NET Program Coordinators Are Responsible For:

- Identifying available free transportation options (e.g., recipient's own vehicle, rides from family, friends, or volunteers). Medicaid does not reimburse if free transportation is available, unless a hardship is verified by Alabama Medicaid
- Confirming eligibility (transportation is not reimbursed for ineligible recipients)
- Submitting medical documentation to support medical necessity for transportation
- Determining the least costly transportation method
- Coordinating in-state and out-of-state commercial travel (bus, train, or air). Medicaid may approve commercial transportation in special circumstances.

Prior Authorization for the NET Program

- All Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) services require prior authorization for payment, except for those specified in Chapter 8, *Ambulance*, Section 8.2.2 (*Non-Emergency Ambulance Services*), and services involving **urgent care**.
- **Urgent care** refers to medical services needed outside of normal business hours. In such cases, reimbursement requests must be submitted on the first business day following the transportation.
- Medicaid may reimburse recipients for public transportation fares when they are able to use it for medical appointments. Public transportation should be used whenever possible. Before approving other modes of transportation, coordinators must confirm that public transit does not meet the recipient's needs.
- For **out-of-state medical transportation**, a physician must submit a statement to Medicaid justifying the need for out-of-state care and confirming that the required services are not available in-state.

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G.1 Benefits and Limitations

Program-Specific Benefits and Limitations

This section outlines the specific benefits and limitations of the Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) Program. For general benefit information and limitations, refer to **Chapter 3: Verifying Recipient Eligibility**. For general criteria regarding Medical Necessity or Medically Necessary Care, see **Chapter 7: Understanding Your Rights and Responsibilities as a Provider**.

The NET Program provides transportation benefits to eligible Medicaid recipients and includes certain service limitations as described in this section.

Escorts

An escort is a person who is not employed by a NET transportation provider and whose presence is necessary to assist a Medicaid recipient during travel or at the site of medical treatment. Escorts are typically relatives, guardians, or volunteers. Only one escort is allowed per recipient, and the need for an escort must be clearly documented.

Medicaid permits escorts for recipients under the age of 21 without additional documentation. For recipients aged 21 and older, escort services may be approved for in-state or out-of-state travel only if a medical certification is submitted. This certification must confirm that the recipient has a physical or mental disability that requires personal assistance. Qualifying conditions include:

- Blindness
- Deafness
- Intellectual and developmental disabilities
- Mental illness
- Physical disabilities requiring assistance

Covered Services Under the NET Program

The Medicaid Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) program may be used to access the following medical services:

- Early and Periodic Screening, Diagnosis, and Treatment (EPSDT)
- Inpatient hospital services
- Outpatient hospital services
- Physician services
- Diagnostic services, such as X-rays and laboratory tests
- Clinic services, including family planning, rural health, and community mental health services
- Dental services (for recipients aged 21 and under)
- Orthotic and prosthetic services
- Vision and eye care services
- Transportation provided by relatives or individuals residing in the same household as the Medicaid recipient
- Transportation using the Medicaid recipient’s or a relative’s personal vehicle
- Transportation for Plan First recipients

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NOTE:
Medicaid reimburses transportation service to a physician's office through the NET Program only when prior authorized.

NET Resources

The Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) Program provides the following resources for recipients who require medical care and lack other transportation options. Coordinators are responsible for selecting the most cost-effective mode of transportation that meets the recipient's needs:

- **Automobile (Volunteer Driver):** Medicaid encourages shared rides when possible. Volunteer drivers may be reimbursed for round-trip transportation from the recipient's home (or place of admission/discharge), unless Medicaid determines that additional mileage reimbursement is more economical.
- **Minibus**
- **Wheelchair Vans:** Escorts may accompany recipients when prior approval is obtained from Medicaid.
- **Bus (Commercial or City Transit):** Available for both in-state and out-of-state travel.
- **Airplane Transportation**
- **Train Service**
- **Escort Services:** Reimbursed for actual ticket costs for minibus, automobile, commercial bus, train, and airplane transportation.

Meals and Lodging

- When overnight travel is necessary for medical care, Medicaid covers meals and lodging for the recipient and one authorized escort. Reimbursement is limited to $50 per person, per day. Receipts or proof of expenses must be submitted before reimbursement is issued.

The Medicaid Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) program does not provide coverage for the following services:

- Transportation when the Medicaid recipient is not a passenger in the vehicle, unless it is determined to be the most economical option
- Meals and lodging expenses incurred by volunteer drivers
- The use of medical supplies during transport, such as oxygen or intravenous fluids
- Transportation for medical services not covered under the Medicaid program
- Transportation services rendered after the death of a Medicaid recipient
- Minibus or wheelchair van travel that extends more than 30 miles beyond the state border
- Services requiring prior authorization when such authorization has not been obtained
- Services that are not medically necessary or are not provided in accordance with program regulations

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G.2 Frequently Asked Questions

What is Non-Emergency Transportation (NET)?

Medicaid's Non-Emergency Transportation (NET) program is designed to assist eligible individuals with transportation to and from medical appointments, such as visits to doctor's offices, clinics, or other healthcare facilities. NET covers transportation by car, bus, or van, and may also include rides from family members, friends, or neighbors. Additionally, public transportation options, such as city buses or local group services, can be covered under the program.

The NET program helps cover the cost of planned transportation to medical appointments and is intended for non-emergency situations.

Who Can Get a Ride?

To receive transportation covered by Medicaid, the individual must be enrolled in Medicaid for the scheduled appointment and must have prior approval for the ride. The transportation must be medically necessary, and requests for rides are typically made a few days ahead of the appointment. Medicaid will not pay for rides if the person is not covered or if the ride is not approved in advance.

How Does the Program Work?

To have Medicaid pay for a ride, you (or someone assisting you) must call Medicaid's toll-free number at **1-800-362-1504**. When you call, the operator will ask for information to verify your Medicaid coverage and assess your need for transportation. This information helps determine if Medicaid can cover your ride.

The NET hotline is available **Monday through Friday, from 8:00 a.m. to 4:00 p.m.**, except on state holidays. You must request transportation **at least five days before the appointment**, or within **24 hours after urgent/emergency care**. Medicaid does not cover rides to the emergency room for non-urgent issues that can wait until a doctor's office or clinic is open.

What Should You Do?

1. **First, try to arrange your own ride** through family, friends, or local groups that offer transportation.
2. If those options aren't available, **call the toll-free hotline** to speak to an operator who can help arrange your ride.
3. If you need frequent medical care (like for dialysis or cancer treatments), a special Medicaid worker may assist you with ongoing transportation arrangements.

If approved for a ride, you'll be informed about available local resources or groups that can provide transportation at little or no cost.

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What if I Have an Emergency?

If you have an emergency, call **911** (or your local emergency number) to get help from an ambulance or paramedics. Medicaid covers ambulance rides in emergencies, such as when someone is not breathing or has sustained serious injuries.

What Do I Do if I Have a Medical Problem That Can't Wait?

A medical problem that requires immediate attention but is not life-threatening is considered an "urgent" medical issue. Examples include broken arms, severe cuts, a baby with a severe earache, or mild chest pains.

If you need to pay for a ride to the emergency room or doctor's office for an urgent problem outside of normal hours, call Medicaid's toll-free hotline as soon as possible after the visit to apply for reimbursement. Medicaid covers rides to the emergency room for urgent medical problems but does not cover rides for non-urgent issues that can wait until a doctor's office or clinic is open.

How Much Will Medicaid Pay for a Ride?

Medicaid will cover what is considered reasonable and necessary to ensure you receive the required medical care. If you have questions about the payment amount, you can ask the operator when you call the toll-free number.

What Do I Do if I Have to Pay for a Ride to See the Doctor on the Weekend?

If you need to pay for a ride on the weekend or after hours, call Medicaid's toll-free number the next business day. Provide the operator with the details of where you went for care and why the ride was necessary. Depending on the situation, Medicaid may reimburse you for the ride you paid for.

Will Medicaid Pay for Someone to Go with Me?

Medicaid will pay for an escort if you are a child or an adult who cannot travel alone due to a physical or mental disability.

How Many Rides Will Medicaid Pay For?

Medicaid only covers rides to doctor appointments or clinics for services covered under Medicaid. Once you have reached your limit for covered doctor visits in a given period, Medicaid will no longer pay for transportation to doctor appointments.

How Will Medicaid Pay for My Ride?

If your ride is approved, Medicaid will send your reimbursement via an **Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT)**. Once your transportation request is verified by a NET worker, the reimbursement will be loaded onto an **EBT card**. The card can be used for cash withdrawals or cash purchases at stores that display the **Quest** logo.

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If approved for transportation reimbursements, you will receive a personalized EBT card along with a brochure explaining how to use it. The card must be activated with a PIN before you can use it.

What happens if I have another insurance plan?

Under federal regulations, Medicaid is designated as the payer of last resort. This means that if a recipient has transportation benefits covered by another insurance plan or program, Medicaid will not provide duplicate coverage for those services.

Medicaid's Non-Emergency Medical Transportation (NET) program is intended to assist recipients in obtaining transportation to medical appointments only when they have no other means of transportation. In cases where another plan already provides transportation services, Medicaid will not offer additional coverage.

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